

lower socio-economic environment might conclude they will always be bad with money or have limited prospects because of their start in life, while those who attended the right private school and come from a wealthy family might presume they're good with money. And if we believe these Money Stories, they can become self-actualising. This may not be problematic if it's a helpful story, but it's dangerous if it's a limiting one.

If you want to break that cycle, to throw out the notions of good versus bad or whether you can or you can't, you need to start by thinking about what your Money Story might be, acknowledging from our discussion so far that you might find this difficult. But I want you, just for a moment, to let go of these beliefs about whether you're bad or good with money. Instead, I want you to take this moment to appreciate that this is about self-discovery rather than how financially knowledgeable you are. To quote Dr Brené Brown, a shame researcher from the University of Houston, whose work we'll talk about more in future chapters: 'What we know matters but who we are matters more'.

Here, what we're doing with our Financial Phenotypes is working out who we are when it comes to how we behave with money, and figuring out whether that is hindering us or helping us.

Perhaps I've convinced some of you by now that it's worth understanding your Money Story, but my guess is I haven't convinced everyone. So, let me present a different argument for why it's important: I believe too many people are living out a Money Story that is causing them to spend or invest in a way that falls outside their values.

Think about it like this. You may have decided you want a life that doesn't cause harm to others. Maybe you've decided intrinsically that you want your 'life story' to be about wellness and nurturing the environment. But your Money Story might in fact cause you to behave in a way that doesn't align with that life value. For example, you might have taken part in climate change marches and yet be investing in fossil fuel companies with your superannuation fund or be contributing to environmental damage with your addiction to fast fashion or weekly overseas parcel purchases.

Now, sometimes this sort of thing can happen because of poor financial knowledge—simply being unaware of the financial impacts of choices. But too often I see people operating outside their values because they're living